

— DAYFORCE · IMPLEMENTATION READINESS · CONSIDERATION

Dayforce Data Migration Checklist: Clean, Map, Reconcile

DF03

Keyword: Dayforce data migration

BlogPosting plus BreadcrumbList

Plus Jakarta Sans + DM Sans

2,014 words

— EDITORIAL BRIEF · DF03

PRIMARY KEYWORD

Dayforce data migration

PROVISIONAL URL

/blog/dayforce-data-migration-checklist

RECOMMENDED SCHEMA

BlogPosting and BreadcrumbList

META DESCRIPTION

Dayforce data migration requires more than loading files. Use this checklist to clean, map, test, reconcile, approve, and cut over your HCM data safely.

SERIES

Dayforce implementation-readiness series · Claude handoff 08 / 10

PRODUCTION NOTE

Preserve the title, direct answer, metadata, factual caveats, sources, and final CTA during the Claude implementation handoff.

FUNNEL / READER INTENT

Consideration and implementation

DRAFT LENGTH

2,014 words

CONVERSION CTA

Ask Align HCM to assess your Dayforce data-conversion readiness.

— DIRECT ANSWER

A Dayforce data migration is ready only when the customer has decided what to retain, cleaned the source data, approved source-to-target mappings, completed trial conversions, reconciled totals and records, resolved exceptions, and signed off on the final cutover file.

Loading data into Dayforce proves that a file was accepted. It does not prove that the right records moved, that values were transformed correctly, or that payroll and workforce operations can trust the result.

Treat Dayforce data migration as a controlled business workstream with technical execution. That means named data owners, repeatable rules, measurable reconciliation, and evidence for every approval.

— KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Decide what data and history must move before extraction begins.
- Assign a business owner to every data domain.
- Clean source data before migration whenever possible.
- Approve source-to-target mappings and transformation rules.
- Run multiple trial conversions using repeatable processes.
- Reconcile counts, values, balances, relationships, and exceptions.
- Control late changes, delta loads, cutover, rollback, and final signoff.
- Preserve legacy access and conversion evidence according to retention requirements.

Why Dayforce data migration is not only an IT task

Technology teams can extract, transform, and load records. They usually cannot decide whether an employee status is correct, whether a benefit election is valid, whether a year-to-date payroll balance is complete, or which legacy history the business needs.

Dayforce's current implementation guidance says customers should identify what data needs to migrate, locate it, clean it before movement, verify employee records after migration, and preserve access to old data. Those activities require decisions from HR, payroll, benefits, finance, security, legal, and operations.

The customer owns the meaning of the data. A vendor or partner can provide templates, tools, and expertise, but business owners must approve the rules and results.

Wang and Strong's data-quality framework makes the same point empirically. Consumers assess data across intrinsic, contextual, representational, and accessibility dimensions, which means fitness for use is a business judgement about context and purpose rather than a technical measure of correctness.

1. Decide what belongs in Dayforce

Start with retention and operating requirements, not with every field in the legacy database.

For each data domain, decide:

- What Dayforce needs to operate on day one
- What history users need inside the new platform
- What data should remain in a secure archive
- What data must be retained for legal, payroll, tax, audit, or policy reasons

- What information should not be migrated
- Who can access retained legacy information
- How long the organization must preserve it

Moving unnecessary history can increase effort and risk. Moving too little can leave payroll, reporting, employee service, or compliance without required context.

Document the decision before files are built.

2. Build a source–system inventory

Data rarely comes from one clean HCM database.

Inventory every source that contributes to Dayforce, including:

- Core HR
- Payroll
- Time and attendance
- Scheduling
- Benefits administration
- Recruiting and onboarding
- Learning and talent
- Identity and access systems
- Finance and general ledger
- Spreadsheets and local databases
- Third-party providers
- Acquired-company systems
- Historical archives

For each source, record the system owner, technical owner, extract method, file format, refresh frequency, data population, security classification, known issues, and planned retirement date.

This inventory also helps separate migration from ongoing integration. A one-time historical load and a recurring production feed require different designs.

3. Assign owners by data domain

One project-level “data owner” is rarely enough.

DATA DOMAIN	TYPICAL BUSINESS OWNER	APPROVAL FOCUS
Person and employment	HR operations	Identity, status, dates, assignments, managers
Organization and jobs	HR and finance	Entities, departments, cost centers, job codes
Payroll	Payroll	Pay groups, elections, balances, earnings, deductions, taxes
Time and scheduling	Workforce operations	Policies, balances, schedules, time entries
Benefits	Benefits	Plans, eligibility, elections, dependents, beneficiaries
Security	HRIS and security	Roles, access, sensitive fields, segregation
Finance and costing	Finance	Accounts, cost allocation, labor distribution
Talent	Talent teams	Goals, reviews, skills, learning, recruiting history

The owner should approve definitions, cleanup rules, mappings, reconciliation, and final acceptance for the domain.

4. Profile the source data

Do not wait for the first failed load to discover data quality.

Profile each source for:

- Required fields that are blank
- Duplicate people or identifiers
- Invalid dates
- Inactive values still in use
- Orphaned records
- Broken manager or organization relationships
- Inconsistent codes
- Unexpected formats
- Out-of-range values
- Conflicting records across systems
- Employees assigned to the wrong population
- Sensitive fields included without a business need

Quantify the findings. “Data needs cleanup” is not actionable. “Thirty-two active employees have no valid department and five share an employee identifier” can be assigned and resolved.

5. Clean the data at the source when possible

Correcting source data provides a cleaner final extract and prevents the old system from remaining inconsistent during implementation.

When source correction is not possible, define an approved transformation rule. Every rule should state:

- The condition that triggers it
- The value or format produced
- The business owner
- The approval date
- The affected records
- Whether the rule is temporary or permanent
- How it will be tested

Avoid hidden manual fixes inside one trial file. If the process cannot be repeated, the final cutover will not be controlled.

6. Create a source-to-target mapping workbook

The mapping workbook is the contract between business meaning and technical execution.

Include:

MAPPING FIELD	PURPOSE
Data domain	Groups related records
Source system and field	Identifies the origin
Source definition	Explains what the value means today
Dayforce target	Identifies the destination object or field
Target definition	Confirms intended meaning
Transformation rule	Documents conversion logic
Default rule	Defines approved handling for blanks

MAPPING FIELD	PURPOSE
Validation	Lists format, value, and relationship checks
Owner	Assigns business accountability
Status and version	Shows approval and change history

Code mapping deserves the same discipline. Legacy earning, deduction, job, location, department, and benefit codes may not have one-to-one Dayforce equivalents.

7. Protect data through the conversion process

Migration files can contain highly sensitive personal and payroll information.

Define:

- Approved extraction and storage locations
- Encryption in transit and at rest
- Access by role
- Secure transfer methods
- File-retention and deletion rules
- Non-production masking requirements
- Vendor and partner access
- Logging and incident escalation
- Final destruction of temporary working files

Use the minimum data required for each purpose. A test team should not receive sensitive fields simply because they exist in the source.

8. Build repeatable extracts and load files

Trial conversion should resemble final conversion.

Automate repeatable steps where practical, preserve version control, and record:

- Extract date and time
- Source environment
- Population criteria
- File version
- Transformation version

- Record counts
- Control totals
- Load environment
- Load result
- Rejected records
- Corrections and reruns

Manual intervention should be visible, approved, and reproducible.

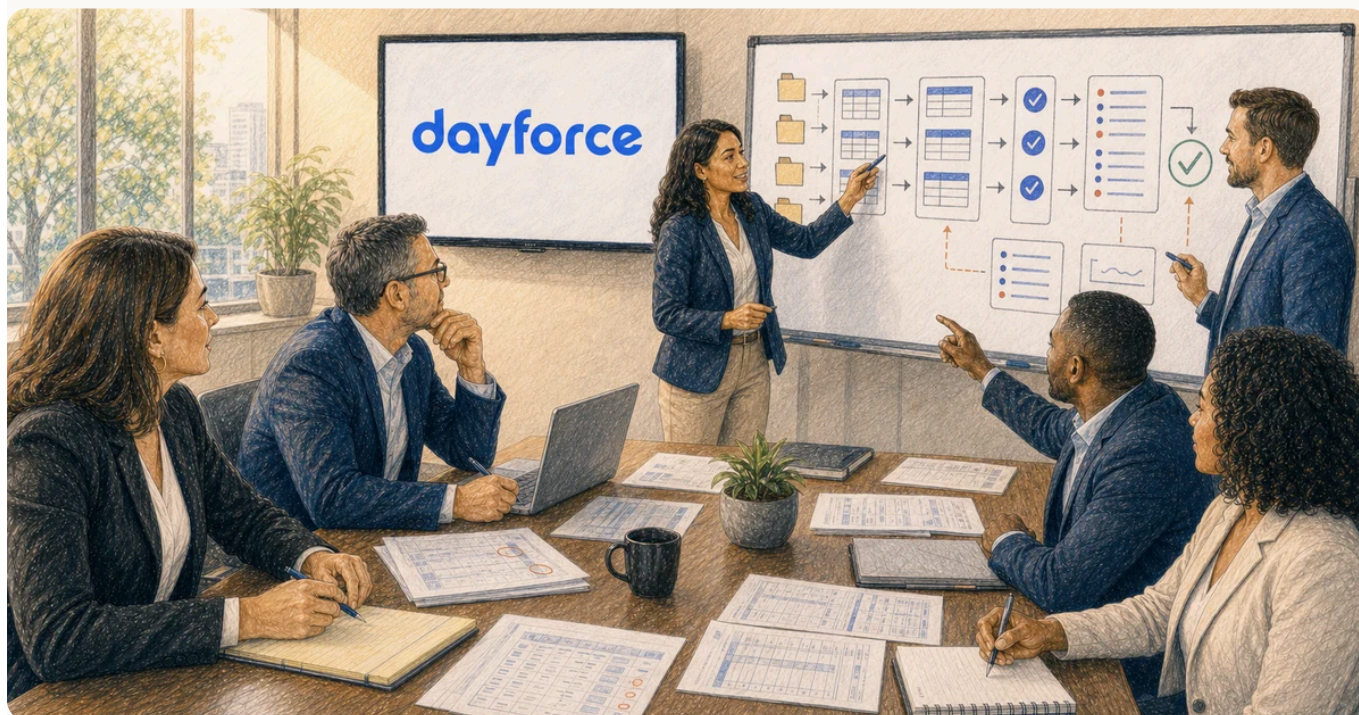
9. Run multiple trial conversions

One successful load is not enough.

A useful sequence includes:

- 1 **Structure trial:** Prove formats, required fields, and basic mappings.
- 2 **Population trial:** Load a broad and representative data set.
- 3 **Reconciliation trial:** Prove counts, totals, relationships, and values.
- 4 **Process rehearsal:** Execute the planned cutover steps and timings.
- 5 **Final conversion:** Use approved extracts, transformations, and signoff controls.

Each trial should reduce uncertainty. Track whether errors come from the source, mapping, transformation, load process, Dayforce configuration, or test environment.



Conversion runs from source inventory through cleanup, mapping, trial loads, and reconciliation to a domain-based signoff.
Original Align HCM illustration.

10. Reconcile more than record counts

Record counts are necessary but incomplete.

Use several levels of reconciliation:

RECONCILIATION LEVEL	EXAMPLES
Population	Employees, dependents, assignments, jobs, plans, balances
Control totals	Salary, hours, year-to-date earnings, deductions, taxes, leave balances
Relationships	Manager hierarchy, department, position, dependent, beneficiary
Code distribution	Pay groups, job codes, locations, benefit plans, statuses
Sample validation	Detailed review of high-risk and representative employees
Exception review	Rejected, defaulted, transformed, or excluded records
Downstream result	Payroll, eligibility, security, reporting, and integration behavior

Dayforce can contain the correct number of employees while still assigning them to the wrong department, manager, pay group, or security role. Reconciliation must test meaning, not only quantity.

Data accuracy is one of the critical success factors [Umble, Haft and Umble](#) identify for ERP implementation, and it is the one most often assumed rather than demonstrated.

11. Validate payroll and time data separately

Payroll conversion has additional dependencies and consequences.

Validate, as applicable:

- Pay groups and calendars
- Direct-deposit information
- Earning and deduction elections
- Tax setup
- Garnishments
- Benefit deductions
- Year-to-date balances
- Accrual and leave balances
- Time entries

- Rates and compensation history
- Retroactive transactions
- Employer liabilities

Converted payroll data should feed the Dayforce parallel-testing process once that article is published. Data reconciliation and payroll comparison are related controls, but one does not replace the other.

12. Control late changes and delta loads

Data continues to change while implementation is underway.

Define:

- The configuration and data freeze dates
- Which transactions can continue
- How changes after the full extract are captured
- How delta records are identified
- Who approves late corrections
- When the final extract runs
- How duplicates and missed records are prevented
- How the final load is reconciled

Rehearse the delta process before cutover. A clean full-load process can still fail if late hires, terminations, pay changes, or benefit events are missed.

13. Sign off on the final cutover

The final approval should be explicit and domain-based.

Before signoff, confirm:

- Approved scope and retention decisions
- Approved mapping and transformation versions
- Successful final extract and load
- Record and control-total reconciliation
- Resolved or accepted exceptions
- Validated security and access
- Completed downstream testing
- Confirmed delta-load results
- Legacy archive available

- Rollback or contingency plan ready
- Business-owner approvals complete

The technical team can confirm that the job ran. Business owners must confirm that the result is usable.

Dayforce data migration red flags

- The team plans to “move everything” without a retention decision.
- Data cleanup has no owner or deadline.
- Mapping decisions live only in email or consultant notes.
- Trial files contain manual fixes that cannot be reproduced.
- The project reports only accepted and rejected record counts.
- Payroll balances are not reconciled to approved controls.
- Testing uses a narrow sample that excludes complex employees.
- Security is validated after the data is loaded.
- Late changes and delta loads have not been rehearsed.
- Legacy-system access will disappear immediately at go-live.
- Final approval comes from the technical team alone.

How Align HCM can help

Align HCM's **data conversion services** help customers define scope, ownership, mapping, trial loads, reconciliation, exception management, and cutover readiness.

Align also supports Dayforce **implementation**, **integrations**, **client-side governance**, testing, training, and post-go-live support.

Contact Align HCM for a free, no-obligation assessment of your Dayforce data-migration plan, mapping, or conversion risk.

Frequently asked questions

Q What data should be migrated to Dayforce?

Migrate the data required to operate Dayforce, support users, meet reporting and retention requirements, and complete payroll or workforce processes. Preserve other required history in an approved archive.

Q Who owns Dayforce data migration?

Technical teams and implementation partners execute much of the process, but customer business owners should approve definitions, cleanup, mappings, reconciliation, exceptions, and final acceptance.

Q How many trial conversions are needed?

The number depends on scope and risk. The project should run enough repeatable trials to prove structure, population, mappings, reconciliation, cutover timing, and final readiness.

Q Is a successful load the same as successful migration?

No. A successful load shows that records met technical requirements. Successful migration also requires complete scope, correct values and relationships, reconciliation, business validation, and signoff.

Q Can Align HCM assist with Dayforce data conversion?

Align HCM provides data-conversion and client-side implementation services. The exact role should be scoped around the customer's sources, history, payroll requirements, timeline, and internal capacity.

Conversion CTA

Ask Align HCM to assess your Dayforce data-conversion readiness.

[Talk to an Align HCM expert](#)

● PUBLICATION NOTES

Recommended visual: a seven-stage conversion pipeline labeled Inventory, Clean, Map, Protect, Trial Load, Reconcile, and Sign Off.

Image implementation: Upload the 1200x627 WebP to the production CMS or CDN, replace the relative review path, retain the descriptive alt text, and include the final image URL in Article image and WebPage primaryImageOfPage markup. This is an original Align HCM illustration; no third-party attribution is required.

Recommended schema: BlogPosting and BreadcrumbList. Keep the visible FAQ for readers and answer engines, but do not use FAQPage rich-result markup.

Recommended inbound links after publication: Dayforce implementation, Dayforce implementation cost, the future integration-scope article, and the payroll parallel-testing article.

Source URLs: the Dayforce, Government of Canada, and Align HCM source pages listed below are carried as link fields in the editorial master. Attach each production URL before publication; only URLs already verified against a live alignhcm.com path are printed in this review PDF.

● SOURCES

- **Dayforce: How to implement an HCM system successfully**
- **Dayforce: HCM deployment timeline and implementation plan**
- **Dayforce Activate: Payroll Comparison**
- **Government of Canada: Fall 2025 HR and pay progress report**
- **Align HCM data conversion services**
<https://www.alignhcm.com/services/data-conversion>
- **Align HCM Dayforce implementation**
<https://www.alignhcm.com/services/implementation>

● RESEARCH SOURCES

Peer-reviewed and published research cited inline above. Every DOI was verified to resolve to the cited article.

- Wang, R. Y., & Strong, D. M. (1996). Beyond accuracy: What data quality means to data consumers. *Journal of Management Information Systems*, 12(4), 5–33.
<https://doi.org/10.1080/07421222.1996.11518099>
- Umble, E. J., Haft, R. R., & Umble, M. M. (2003). Enterprise resource planning: Implementation procedures and critical success factors. *European Journal of Operational Research*, 146(2), 241–257.
[https://doi.org/10.1016/S0377-2217\(02\)00547-7](https://doi.org/10.1016/S0377-2217(02)00547-7)